

the Mississippi River—most within 50 miles (80km) of the eastern coastline. If more western territory could be added, Jefferson envisaged a nation mighty enough to compete economically with and to defend itself against the great European powers. Skeptics pointed to transportation difficulties, the presence of American Indians, and foreign claims to North American territory as barriers to expansion.

In the early 19th century, a letter mailed in Maine took 20 days to arrive in Charleston, South Carolina, because of the scarcity and roughness of the roads. The War of 1812—which lasted until 1815—encouraged people to build better roads and connections among the various states for the purpose of defense. After the war, growing markets, westward migration, and military concerns continued to drive communities and private investors to construct roads, bridges, and canals, which speeded up the exchange of goods and tied people together. One of the most ambitious of these projects, the Erie Canal, eventually connected New York City to Lake Erie and the Upper Midwest states and territories. New York state and private investors funded the canal, which was started in 1817 and completed in 1825. It would pay for itself in seven years.

In the 1830s, railroads began to supplant canals as a faster, cheaper mode of carrying passengers and freight. Popular demand and congressional policy encouraged the creation of post offices along the frontiers, and soon the nation had more postal clerks than soldiers. The telegraph appeared in the 1840s following alongside the railroads, as cities, hoping to exchange business and political intelligence, clamored to join the network. Advances in paper and printing technology made newspapers cheaper, and the advent of the Associated Press in 1846 created rapid standardized reporting from around the nation.

Northern transformations

Most Northern farming families focused on self-reliance and subsistence, raising their own food and bartering locally to maintain their independence. As transportation improved, people farming